

AI marketing tools for a small business: the ones that respect your brand

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AI marketing tools for a small business: the ones that respect your brand

By Dillon Mohr, Momentum Digital, Philadelphia

The AI marketing tools worth paying for are the ones that read a brand file and stop when the output breaks it. Color, type, logo, voice and the claims you're allowed to make, written down once. Then a gate in front of anything that ships. The tool matters less than the file and the gate in front of it.

I'll show you what that means with our own numbers, because we measured our own work before we measured anyone else's.

Why do AI marketing tools produce generic work?

"AI marketing tools" gets about 4,400 searches per month in the US. "AI tools for small businesses" adds 880. "Brand consistency AI" gets zero. Nobody searches for the problem. Everybody has it.

Generic output isn't a prompt problem. It's a system problem. The tool has nothing to read. You typed "make a Facebook post for my landscaping company" and it made one for every landscaping company. Better prompts get you a better version of the same thing. A brand file gets you yours.

We put it on the launch film for our AI division as three words: built, not prompted.

What is a brand file?

One document a machine can read. Five parts.

1. **Voice.** The words you use and the words you never use. Our never-list has about a dozen words on it, the ones every agency website uses and nobody says out loud. If it sounds like a billboard, it's on the list. Short sentences. Periods.
2. **Palette.** Every color with its measured contrast ratio against every surface it appears on. Not a swatch. A number.
3. **Type.** Which fonts, how many sizes. Two families is plenty.
4. **Logo rules.** Where it goes, how big it gets. Our own site generator never displays a logo above about 1.4 times its native width, because that's where they start to blur.
5. **Claims.** What you can prove and what you can't. "Family-owned since 2015" if it's true. "Best in the city" never.

That's it. One page, maybe two. Every tool you use reads it first.

What does "fails the design test" mean?

It means the words can't be read. Here's what we found when we tested ourselves.

In September 2026 we measured ten prospect homepages our own system had shipped. Twelve color pairs per site, 120 pairs total. 37 failed the WCAG AA contrast standard. Nine of the ten sites had the same failure: a muted text color that had been derived against a white background but rendered on a gray panel, landing between 4.28 and 4.49 to 1 where 4.5 is the floor. Nine near-misses in a row isn't ten mistakes. It's one formula validating against a surface the text never sits on. One hero eyebrow measured 1.01 to 1. Invisible.

Then we measured our own homepage. Five font families. Twenty different corner radii. Body copy at 3.25 to 1. Worse than the prospect sites.

The replacement design system carries 31 color pairs at zero failures, and the build script refuses to render if any pair fails. That's the gate. "Never fails the design test" is true of the gate. It was not true of everything we'd shipped before it. We're saying both out loud, in that order.

Why can't one orange do two jobs?

This is the specific thing most AI tools get wrong on day one.

Our orange is #f58320. As a button fill with near-black text on it, the contrast is 7.19 to 1. Passes easily. As text on a white background, the same orange is 2.58 to 1. Fails. Same hex, two jobs, one of them impossible.

So the accent splits. One orange for fills. A darker one for text on white. Two tokens, each with one job.

Every tool that "matches your brand color" by pasting your hex into a headline has just failed accessibility with your logo color. The brand file catches it because the ratio is written next to the color. The tool won't.

Which tools respect a brand file?

I won't rate tools I haven't measured, and I haven't measured most of them. So here's the test instead. Six questions for any AI design or content tool:

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1. Can it take a token file, hex codes with ratios, rather than a mood board?
 2. Does it keep the logo at its native proportions, or does it stretch and blur?
 3. Can you lock the fonts?
 4. Does it export editable files, or only flat images?
 5. Does it tell you what it used?
 6. Can you put a check between it and publish?

Number six is the one that matters. For our own video batch, a QA script scans every rendered frame for colors that aren't in the palette before the file goes anywhere, and the wordmark file is hash-checked against the canonical logo. Every word on screen is typed, not generated, because generated type drifts. That's what "respects the brand" means in practice: the output can be checked, and it gets checked.

What should an AI marketing agency deliver each month?

"AI marketing agency" gets about 1,900 searches per month in the US, and nobody agrees on what one delivers. Here's what a month of production looks like in our own scope, so you have something to compare against:

- One brand, one written brief.
- Four original concepts.
- Up to eight size variants of the approved ones.
- Editable files, not just exports.
- One consolidated revision round.
- A readiness summary that says what was checked.

Not included: shoots, custom animation, paid placement. And a warning that goes with it: volume of creative is not proof of business results. Forty posts a month that nobody reads is forty posts.

Ask any agency, including us, for its own contrast audit. If it can't produce one, it hasn't measured its own work.

FAQ

Do I need a designer if I have AI tools? You need a brand file and someone who can read a contrast ratio. That's a smaller job than a full-time designer and a bigger one than nobody.

What's the minimum brand file? One page. Two colors with their ratios, one or two fonts, logo size rules, ten words you never use, three claims you can prove.

Can AI make my marketing video? Parts of it. Generated backgrounds and motion, with your real logo and real type laid on top. Every word on screen should be typed, not generated.

The next step

If you want to know whether your current output passes the test, I'll do a 15-minute snapshot: three observations about your brand as it ships today, with the evidence for each, and one suggested next step. Free. No deck, no pitch. Reach me through needmomentum.com.

Momentum built the machine. Now we build yours.